Poster Description:

- Function: This poster was commissioned for a poster exhibition at TypeCon in Portland, Oregon, USA. TypeCon is an annual typography and type design conference.
- Concept: The designer described the poster as, "A love letter from LA to Portland and from Portland to LA." The poster can be hung either with the "L" at the top or the "P" at the top. "LAX" is the airport code for Los Angeles, and "PDX" is the airport code for Portland.
- Additional details: The poster was printed in an edition of 10 posters. Posters from this exhibition were also offered for sale during the opening. The designer lives and works in Los Angeles, California, USA.

Which of the statements below most precisely describes the audience for the poster? There is more than one correct answer for this question.

- [ ] people who live in Portland and/or Los Angeles
- [x] graphic designers

✓ **Correct**

Because graphic designers are the primary audience for TypeCon, they would also be a primary audience for the poster. Identifying a specific audience helps us interpret or understand intention as well as content and design decisions.

- [x] TypeCon attendees

✓ **Correct**

TypeCon attendees are mostly likely graphic designers, type designers or ina related field. They would also be a primary audience for the poster.

- [ ] people who go to museums
- [ ] people who live in cities

2. Which statement most specifically describes the primary function or job of the poster shown in question 1?

- (●) to use typography to express an idea about Portland and Los Angeles
- ( ) to generate revenue for the gallery
- ( ) to advertise the TYPECON conference
- ( ) to promote tourism in Portland

✓ **Correct**

We could describe the poster imagery as "type as image"—in other words, the letters are the imagery. The interlocking letterforms and the fact that the poster can be hung right side up or upside down communicate an idea of a back-and-forth relationship, or dialogue, between Portland and LA.

3. Why is “sharpening” important in evaluating visual form?

- ○ Sharpening refers to an increase in the vertical scale of a composition.
- ○ Pencils are a crucial tool for designers and must be maintained by sharpening.
- ○ Symmetry is important in all compositions and sharpening is a way to ensure alignment of all objects.
- ◉ Visual contrast is crucial to effective design, sharpening refers to the way a designer creates contrast in a composition with exaggeration and the use of disruptive visual elements.
- ○ Sharpening refers to the way harmony and asymmetry work to create a dynamic composition through the use of basic shapes and primary colors.

✓ **Correct**

Visual contrast is directly related to hierarchy, communication and visual interest. Controlled visual contrast is crucial to effective design. “Sharpening” refers to an approach to composition that involves extreme or exaggerated visual contrasts.

4. Choose the sentence that best defines “leveling”:

- ○ The method of creating clear visual contrast in a composition.
- ◉ A technique to create more harmonious compositions by weakening and toning down visual difference and contrast.
- ○ A flat picture plane with high levels of visual contrast.
- ○ A perceptual tendency to find proportional relationships in all objects.
- ○ A symmetrical composition.

✓ **Correct**

The technique or approach of leveling reduces overall levels of visual tension and contrast but still maintains a clear visual hierarchy and harmonious composition.

5. Look at the cropped image of the TypeCon poster shown in question 1 below. **Viewed together, which elements create the MOST visual contrast in the image?**

- ○ pink and white elements
- ○ pink and black elements
- ◉ black and white zebra stripes

✓ **Correct**

The black and white zebra stripes have the greatest amount of contrast and types of visual contrast relative to the elements that surround them: contrast of value (black and white); contrast of texture (organic, irregular), contrast of shape (non-geometric)

6. Which sentence best describes the visual contrast in the cropped image of the TypeCon poster shown in the previous question (#5)?

- ○ The vertical bar of pink creates the only contrast in the image.
- ○ Too much complexity and variety creates average levels of contrast.
- ○ There is no contrast in this image, only variations in tone.
- ◉ Pattern, color, line weight, and tone create varied and visually engaging contrast.
- ○ The lack of color in this image creates a flattening of contrast.

✓ **Correct**

There are many types of visual contrast in this cropped section of the poster. They work together to create tension between flat pattern and visual representations of dimensionality (extrusion, drop shadow, etc.). Overall, these contrasts create formal complexity and visual interest.

7. Look again at the cropped image below of the TypeCon poster. **Which principles of visual contrast do you see in the image?**

- ○ Contrast of scale
- ○ Contrast of texture
- ○ Contrast of line
- ○ Contrast of value
- ○ Contrast of color
- ○ None of the above
- ◉ All of the above

✓ **Correct**

Although some of the visual contrasts above may seem similar in this example, they each describe a specific way that visual elements distinguish themselves from each other.

8. Which of principles of visual contrast are the two most important or dominant in the cropped image of the TypeCon poster shown here?

- [ ] Contrast of color
- [x] Contrast of value

✓ **Correct**
The dominant use of black and white shapes creates an extreme contrast of value.

- [ ] Contrast of scale
- [x] Contrast of texture

✓ **Correct**
The contrast of the zebra stripes to the delicate background and the solid pink shapes create the greatest visual distinction and separation in the poster.

Choose the sentence that best describes how tone and positive/negative space creates visual hierarchy in the image of the poster shown above.

- ○ The visual complexity of this poster flattens the space, there is no clear visual hierarchy.
- ○ The centrally aligned elements have low contrast and no negative space, making the poster seem very flat.
- ○ Pattern and strong contrast in tone makes the background the first read in the visual hierarchy.
- ○ The pink-colored elements read as the highest tonal value in the poster and are a good candidate for the #1 read in the hierarchy
- ◉ The use of negative space in the counter (empty space enclosed by a letter) of the letter D and the zebra pattern makes it a strong candidate for the #1 read in the visual hierarchy.

✓ **Correct**

The counter of the D is the only large, white space on the poster. It is also surrounded by large-scale, high contrast (black and white) pattern. Because this area has a unique element (the only solid white shape) in addition to other high levels of visual contrast (value, scale, texture) it is a strong candidate for #1 in the visual hierarchy.

10. How do the geometric patterns in the background of the TypeCon poster shown in the previous question (#9) effect visual hierarchy?

- ○ The patterns are highly distracting and read very high in the hierarchy.
- ◉ The geometric patterns do not read very high in the hierarchy relative to the other elements in the poster.
- ○ The patterns only read as texture, and make it difficult to establish a clear hierarchy.

✓ **Correct**

The geometric patterns are made of fine, evenly spaced lines, in an all-over pattern that recede into the background. They read very low in the hierarchy relative to other, more high contrast elements in the poster.

11. In the poster below, which is the **lowest** element in the visual hierarchy?

    Hint: "lowest" = area of **least** visual contrast; "highest" = area of **most** visual contrast.

    Hierarchy diagram:

    1/ the two pink hearts in the center of the small white circle

    2/ the fine, hairline stripe pattern in the background

    3/ the big black X

- ○ Number 1 - the two pink hearts in the center of the small white circle
- ◉ Number 2 - the fine, hairline stripe pattern in the background
- ○ Number 3 - the big black X

✓ **Correct**

The fine, hairline stripe pattern is the **lowest** element in the visual hierarchy. Because the stripes are thin and close together in an all-over pattern, there is low contrast of value, scale and texture. The stripes fall into the background of the composition.

12. What do you think is the most important idea or information in the poster that is present in the top 3 levels of visual hierarchy? Explain.

Correct

Did your answer mention any of the following details?

The visual hierarchy takes the viewer from the PDX letterforms (#1 the counter of the D) to the repeating content "LAX (hearts) PDX (hearts) LAX (hearts) PDX..." and "it's all good in the hood" (#2 the two pink hearts) and back to the LAX letterforms (#3 the counter of the A). The top three levels of visual hierarchy take the viewer to the 3 groups of content (LAX, PDX, and the message around the two pink hearts).

13. Does the visual hierarchy match or support the function or intention of the poster?

- (●) yes
- ( ) no

✓ **Correct**

The interlocking letterforms and the fact that the poster can be hung right side up or upside down communicate an idea of a back-and-forth relationship, or dialogue, between Portland and LA.

What terms/phrases would you use to describe the composition of the poster?

- ○ centered or symmetrical
- ◉ tension with edges of the page
- ○ off-center or asymmetrical
- ○ strong directional axes

✓ **Correct**

The large interlocking mass seems to be coming up against, but not quite touching, the edge of the page. This makes us aware of how the thin white frame of negative space surrounding the background pattern contrasts with the mass of letterforms and textures that overlap it, creating a sense of tension with the edges of the page.

15. How does the color pink function in the composition of the TypeCon poster shown in the previous question (#14)? Select the best answer.

- ○ The color creates a visual ambiguity that sharpens the composition and makes the letters more legible.
- ○ Distracting, why is it even there?
- ○ Clearly it is a commentary on the relationships between women designers in Portland and Los Angeles.
- ○ It functions to emphasize the letters "L," "X," and "D."
- ◉ The pink creates depth in the composition by subtly highlighting certain letters and creating a visual flow through the poster.

✓ **Correct**

The pink moves the eye to certain parts of the composition by highlighting letters, particularly the "X" which contains the small-scale text.

16. "I like the hearts because they draw my eye to them. They kind of remind me of Valentine's Day."

Rephrase the above statement as an objective explanation for the hearts' importance in the poster. Consider:

- the hearts' position in the overall visual hierarchy (think about contrast of color, scale, negative space, etc.)
- the meaning of the heart as a symbol
- how the hearts interact with the content around them to create meaning
- why there are 2 hearts
- why one of them is upside down

Correct

Did your answer mention any of the following details?

The hearts are a distinct point of contrast: they are the only heart shapes, they are small and surrounded by negative white space. This contrasts to the elements around them and makes them very visible (high in the visual hierarchy) even though they are small. The hearts and the circular message around them give us a clue that the poster has 2 orientations: it can be hung with the "P" at the top or the "L" at the top. The heart is a symbol of love or affection, and in this case, represents the mutual friendship between the two cities. Because it is a mutual friendship (ie a back-and-forth), the content can be read in both directions: LAX (hearts) PDX or PDX (hearts) LAX.